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WATERS A NATION

MY NEXT ENTREPRENEUR COMES FROM LIBERIA, A SMALL country of under 5 million people with a troubled history.¹⁴⁴ In Ghana, I had grown up with first-hand awareness of human rights abuses. My father had founded the African Commission of Health and Human Rights Promoters in the late '80s and I grew up in the '90s with refugees from Liberia who had fled the brutal civil war which claimed over 250,000 lives.¹⁴⁵ I remember torture victims that we would host in our house, like Throble Suah, who had been beaten mercilessly for writing against Charles Taylor. Our home served as a refuge for these survivors of violence. At a young age, I was moved by their courage in the face of such tragedy. The Boduburam refugee settlement in Ghana for example hosted over 38,000 Liberian refugees during the war.¹⁴⁶ Liberians and Ghanaians share a powerful bond.

The Liberia I was visiting in 2016 was different from the Liberia of the '90s. Here was a country that embodied many of the contradictory notions about contemporary Africa which I've been confronted with during my journey. War-torn, but with a fast-growing economy, politically ahead of the curve in some ways (having elected Africa's

first female president), but still deeply attached to ethnic identities and politics, Liberia seemed to simultaneously capture the promise and perils of a fledgling post-conflict nation.

Liberia began as a settlement of the American Colonization Society, an organisation which relocated freed slaves from the United States and the Caribbean. Liberia's first president in 1847, Joseph Jenkins Roberts, was a free-born African American from Virginia. He would also serve as its seventh president in 1872. The Americo-Liberians, as they became known, created a ruling oligarchy, which excluded indigenous Liberians from power. These tensions contributed to a military coup overthrowing President William Tolbert in 1980 and marked the beginning of political instability which would reign for several decades. After the brutal civil wars that resulted in the deaths of over 250,000 people, a peace agreement was reached in 2003, which led to democratic elections in 2005, under which Harvard-trained economist and former Minister of Finance, Ellen Johnson Sirleaf was elected as the first female president in Africa. Driven to the presidency mainly by the outsized contributions of Liberian women, President Sirleaf focused on gender issues, implementing one of the continent's most comprehensive rape laws and setting up a fast-track court to deal with gender violence.¹⁴⁷

"Ma Ellen," as she is popularly called in Liberia won the Nobel Peace Prize in 2011, shortly before she was re-elected for a second term. At the end of 2017, she handed over power to George Weah, the newly elected President of Liberia and a former soccer star, marking the first peaceful democratic transition of power in Liberia in 73 years. Ma Ellen was awarded the \$5 million Ibrahim Prize for Achievement in African Leadership, with the prize committee remarking that 'she took over a country that was devastated and broken by 14 years of civil war and was later struck again by the Ebola crisis... Such a journey cannot be without some shortcomings. Today, Liberia continues to face many challenges.'¹⁴⁸ While Ma Ellen

is celebrated on the international stage, her legacy at home is mixed. Her fellow Nobel laureate Leymah Gbowee quit as head of Liberia's Truth and Reconciliation Commission and criticised President Sirleaf for corruption and nepotism, after she appointed her sons to key posts in the government.¹⁴⁹

The Liberian government under Sirleaf's presidency took an interesting bet on digital technologies as a solution to the country's education challenges. After nearly 25,000 students, and 100% of all test-takers, failed the admission test to the University of Liberia, the country was forced to take radical action.¹⁵⁰ In a global first, they outsourced the running of some of its public schools to Bridge International Academies, a private company backed by Bill Gates and Mark Zuckerberg.¹⁵¹ Described as the "Uber of Education", Bridge uses technology, standardisation and rigorous monitoring, with teachers reading word-for-word from a scripted lesson plan displayed on cheap tablets.¹⁵² While highly controversial – critics have accused Bridge of undermining the teacher-student relationship, charging high fees to poor families, and paying its teachers low wages – initial studies suggested that Bridge schools outperform their public counterparts in Liberia.¹⁵³ Are tablets and digital lesson plans the key to solving Liberia's educational woes? I was headed to Monrovia to meet an entrepreneur tackling a problem even more basic than schools.

As my plane descended into Monrovia, I was surprised to see that most of the planes and helicopters bore the baby-blue UN seal, far outnumbering the commercial vehicles on the tarmac. A UN observation post with armed soldiers still watches over the airport, even though the civil war officially ended a decade and a half ago, in 2003. The cab driver who took me to my hotel proclaimed his devotion to Charles Taylor, the convicted war criminal and former president of Liberia. As we drove through the streets of Monrovia, some of which looked brand new, some of which are still scarred by

bullet holes from the conflict in which Charles Taylor was ousted, my driver declared, 'If he were allowed to run for president again, he would win in a landslide.' I later reflected on this conversation when Taylor's ex-wife was elected as Vice President of Liberia in the 2017 election, on the ticket of George Weah. When I arrived at my hotel, the bellman gave me an impressive pitch as to why I should invest in Liberia. The war had ground the local economy to a standstill, but as this new era of peace and security appeared to be the new normal for Liberia, many people and businesses began returning to work, creating potential for rapid growth.

One of the biggest factors limiting this growth, however, is the dearth of basic infrastructure. I came to Monrovia to meet Saran Kaban Jones, the founder of FACE Africa, a non-profit organisation that provides clean water, sanitation and hygiene programs in remote communities in Liberia. Popularly known as the Water Lady, Saran has made it her life's work to ensure that every Liberian man, woman, and child has access to clean water.

I met Saran in the lobby of my hotel where she was attending a conference on US-Liberian investments. She was wearing a suit that matched the MacBook on which she was furiously typing. She looked tired, but she had a distinct twinkle in her eyes when she spoke about her work. When she saw me, she quickly put aside her computer and gave me a big hug, welcoming me to Liberia. As she was busy, and I was tired from my trip, we agreed to meet at the hotel the next day, when she would take me on a tour of the city before going back to her house to answer my questions about her work.

The next day, we set off early in her car from the hotel to Westpoint, one of Monrovia's most notorious slums. I've always found slums fascinating. OluTimehin Adegbeye summed it up best in her TED talk: 'After all, what is a slum besides an organic response to acute housing deficits and income inequality? And what is a shanty if not a person making a home for themselves against all odds? Slums are

an imperfect housing solution, but they are also prime examples of the innovation, adaptability and resilience at the foundation – and the heart – of every functional city.¹⁵⁴

When I told Saran about how I had been impressed by the signs of development and growth in Liberia; the new roads, the new businesses springing up everywhere, the impressive growth in GDP, she insisted that I visit Westpoint, in order to understand the disconnect between these signs of progress, and the lives of Monrovia's poorest citizens. For our safety, Saran arranged for us to be taken around by some former gangsters who had now become activists and community organisers. Although I was familiar with impoverished neighbourhoods in Accra and Lagos, I was shocked by Westpoint. Young girls, who looked no older than 12 or 13 were being pimped in broad daylight, openly recruiting customers outside the make-shift brothels where they worked. A group of boys, no older than the girls, were smoking and shooting up drugs. The streets were littered with garbage and human waste, from the overflowing refuse heaps, causing a heavy stench that clouded the area. Even the rain that had started to fall couldn't wash away the garbage or the smell. I took out my phone to take some pictures, but our guides warned me to put it away, as it would be snatched in seconds. Saran introduced me to Abigail, a child survivor of sex trafficking at Westpoint. When I met her, she was 13 years old and the top student in her 7th grade class. Abigail has a bright smile that lights up the dark clouds of poverty and hopelessness that hangs over Westpoint. Abigail wants to be a community leader and empower other young girls like her mentor Saran did for her.

Visiting Westpoint was, by far, the most difficult part of my entire trip, and served as an important reminder of the gap between rosy economic numbers, and the lives of the poor and marginalised on the ground who are often excluded from the economic growth. As we climbed back into the car to leave Westpoint, I found I had even

more questions for Saran. What could possibly motivate her to give up her lucrative and prestigious job working in private equity for the Singapore Economic Development Board to work in Monrovia?

‘You know, it never started out that way,’ Saran explained. ‘When I went to college, I wanted to eventually get involved in foreign service, whether it was for the US or for Liberia, I hadn’t figured out at the time because I was going through a major identity crisis: am I American, or am I Liberian? Who am I? What am I? But I knew I wanted to do something internationally because I was really inspired by my father and his work.’

Saran explained to me how her identity as a Liberian, cemented during her childhood partly growing up in the country, motivated this decision to come back and work in Liberia. She described her childhood in Liberia before the war as happy and privileged. Her father was a university professor, her mother was a businesswoman, and she attended St. Michael’s Catholic School, one of the best schools in the country. As a child, Saran dreamed of becoming the first female president of Liberia. A precocious and ambitious student who was usually first in her class, Saran won all the spelling bee competitions.

Although she has always considered Liberia home, Saran considers herself a ‘global citizen’. She is fluent in English, French, Arabic and Mandingo. Saran’s parents were Liberian diplomats and ambassadors, her father originally hailing from Guinea-Conakry, while her late mother is originally from Côte d’Ivoire. When she was eight years old, Saran’s family fled Liberia for Côte d’Ivoire right at the outbreak of the Liberian civil war. After two years in Abidjan, her father was appointed Ambassador to Egypt and the family spent four years there, before moving to France and then Cyprus for two years each. Then Saran came to the United States for college, studying at Lesley College in Cambridge, Massachusetts. She later worked at the W.E.B. Du Bois Institute at Harvard University as a Fellowship Coordinator. Then she moved to Singapore in 2005 to work for the

Singapore Economic Development Board (EDB). EDB is the leading government agency responsible for enhancing Singapore's position as a global business centre and growing the Singaporean economy. Saran's role at the EDB was focused on private equity.

■ In 2005, Saran began sending funds back to Liberia to help one of her brother's friends with his school fees after discovering that his parents couldn't afford it. After two years, he went on to complete high school and enrolled at the University of Liberia. When Saran realised just how much of an impact her few hundred dollars had made, she decided to scale up her efforts and dedicated herself to improving the lives of those less fortunate in Liberia. She was also inspired by Bill Clinton's book, *Giving: How Each of Us Can Change the World*, to do more – something on a larger scale. In early 2008, she launched Fund A Child's Education (FACE) Africa with the goal of providing educational opportunities to children and young adults in Liberia and other war-torn countries.

■ Saran returned to Liberia for the first time in 2008. Saran described her return as overwhelming; the country's two civil wars had radically altered her childhood home. When she returned, she had to stay with a cousin because her parents' house had been burned down in the conflict. While making the rounds visiting relatives whom she hadn't seen in over a decade, Saran was shocked by the devastation and poverty she saw all around the country. Saran decided that the first task of FACE Africa would be to discover what students and teachers wanted and needed to improve education in Liberia. While interviewing principals and teachers at various schools, Saran discovered that every single school complained about the problems caused by the lack of clean water. Students would leave school to look for water to drink, and then get sick from drinking contaminated water, missing days and sometimes weeks of school.

■ Saran told me, 'I thought, "Wow, there's something to this water thing!" It's linked to education, to healthcare, even to a country's

development and GDP, because if you are putting so much stress on a country's healthcare because of basic water-borne diseases, simple things like diarrhoea and typhoid and cholera, then a country can't really develop without tackling the basic need of water. So, it just kept coming back to water, water, water, and I decided "You know what? I'm going to champion this water cause!"

Water wasn't just an issue for Liberia – it is a global issue. The United Nations estimates that 2.2 billion people lack access to safely managed drinking water services and 4.2 billion people lack safely managed sanitation services.¹⁵⁵ Yet, while the challenges of clean water and sanitation are clearly global, South-east Asia and Sub-Saharan Africa face some of the worst problems.¹⁵⁶ Water and sanitation have a very broad impact, covering all genders and age groups, and affecting health, economics, education and the central features of life in a community.

Lack of access to clean water and basic sanitation undermines efforts to end extreme poverty and disease in the world's poorest countries where people in rural areas continue to be disproportionately underserved. Together, unclean water and poor sanitation are one of the leading causes of child mortality: diarrhoea causes about three hundred thousand deaths annually of infants under the age of five.¹⁵⁷ In Liberia, less than 10% of the population has access to safely managed drinking water and sanitation services.¹⁵⁸

As with many challenges in development, women and girls are disproportionately impacted because of their higher exposure rates. Twice as many women as men are responsible for water collection. In addition to higher exposure rates, women in the developing world walk six kilometres each day to collect water, time which could be spent in school or at work. Studies show that more than half of girls who drop out of primary school in Sub-Saharan Africa do so partly because of a lack of separate toilets and lack of access to safe water. The effects of the lack of access to water and sanitation have

a macroeconomic impact as well. The World Health Organisation estimates that the loss of productivity to water and sanitation related diseases costs many countries up to 5% of GDP.¹⁵⁹ Moreover, water and sanitation scarcities will be exacerbated through challenges such as climate change and urbanisation.

Even though Saran was pivoting from education to water and sanitation, she decided to keep the name of the organisation 'because the name FACE Africa can apply to anything... let's face Africa, let's face the challenges and I chose Africa because I am not limiting my work to just Liberia, I want to focus on other African countries and expand beyond Liberia [in the future].' This responsiveness has become something of a hallmark for Saran's work with FACE Africa. Initially, Saran attempted to set up several projects across Liberia, but she soon noticed that FACE Africa's resources were spread too thin to have a measurable impact, so she decided to focus on one region of the country and create a sustainable solution to its water crisis before moving on to do the same in another region.

The region Saran chose was the Rivercess county, one of Liberia's most underdeveloped and rural areas. According to Saran, there is not a single paved road in the whole county. 'There are a number of NGOs here in Liberia,' Saran remarked. 'After the war, the country got a lot of aid money and so there are a lot of NGOs working in the country. At my last count, there were over 150 organisations in Liberia that focus on water, sanitation and hygiene projects: 150 for a country of less than 4 million people. But you don't see the impact, even if you travel 10 or 20 miles outside Monrovia. Even here in Monrovia, there's a huge water and sanitation crisis, but outside of Monrovia it's even worse.'

Saran and her team selected Rivercess county for two important reasons: firstly, because the county is so rural and underdeveloped, virtually no other NGOs were working there, and if FACE Africa could get its projects to work there, it would be easier to scale up

to other counties; and secondly, because the county's population is relatively small, so the challenge of providing clean water to every resident is more manageable for a new organisation with limited resources. Rivercess is under-populated with 115,000 people. The goal was to use Rivercess as a pilot for the greater goal of ensuring that every single person in Liberia has access to safe drinking water.

The first step of the "County by County" initiative was, with the help of county officials and local partners, to conduct a complete countywide assessment of the county's current water and sanitation resources and projected needs. Based on the study that Saran and her team conducted, they estimated a need to install 250 water points in Rivercess. They initially thought the project would cost 1.2 to 1.5 million dollars, and gave themselves a timeline of 5 years, contingent on raising the required funding and increase the capacity of the organisation on the ground. They also realised that by working with local partners to implement the projects, they could scale up faster. As Saran declared, 'We can solve this water crisis...it's not rocket science.'

A part of FACE Africa's model requires spending a considerable amount of time collecting baseline data in beneficiary communities as the analysis of this data is imperative to the planning, design, implementation, monitoring and evaluation of the organisation's interventions in various communities. FACE Africa collects baseline data using participatory methods to ensure that the community has a stake in the success of the project and to reveal any hidden issues that can affect the design and implementation of the interventions.

The baseline data collected includes the background of the community, population, socio-cultural practices, past interventions, infrastructure, existing socio-political structures and their various roles, hygiene practices, economic activities, water and sanitation facilities, leadership structures and communication channels, norms

and taboos, common diseases, perceptions about their community and gender roles.

FACE Africa uses participatory learning approach (PLA) tools to collect the data¹⁶⁰, and analyses the results together with the entire community at community meetings to ensure that the has an ownership stake in the entire process and as a result would be more likely to stay committed to the decisions derived from the analyses. For each community, FACE Africa facilitates the formation of a Water and Sanitation Committee to oversee the operation and maintenance of water, sanitation and hygiene activities. As part of the organisation's model, women make up 50% of the committee structure. Community members are trained by technical engineers; they participate in the construction and installation of any hardware as well as maintenance. FACE Africa commits to monitoring projects for up to 10 years after implementation and has maintained a 100% functionality rate of all its projects since inception.

Saran says the FACE Africa model 'requires us to roll up our sleeves and get our hands dirty.' She emphasises the local elements of their approach – the projects utilises local materials, local labour, and ownership is transferred to the communities upon completion. 'We focus on optimising sustainability of our water projects by forming long-lasting, collaborative relationships with communities. We do not build water systems in isolation. Instead we work with communities to co-create programs that are appropriate for them and the environment in which they live.'

The power of this collaborative, inclusive and participatory approach that empowers local communities became evident during the Ebola outbreak. The World Health Organisation reported cases of Ebola Virus Disease (EVD) in Guinea in 2014 and later that year declared it a public health emergency of international concern. Over the duration of the epidemic, the largest in history, EVD spread to 9 countries: Liberia, Sierra Leone, Italy, Mali, Nigeria, Senegal, Spain,

the United Kingdom and the United States. In Liberia, an estimated 10,678 cases resulted in the deaths of 4,810 people, the highest global death count, before the epidemic was finally contained in 2016.¹⁶¹

According to Saran, part of the challenge during the epidemic was the lack of trust between local communities and Liberia's national government. As a result, many community members would chase out NGOs, believing that EVD was a ploy by the government to obtain more international aid money. In addition, EVD symptoms were like those of other diseases such as malaria and water-borne illnesses so did not immediately raise concerns. Unlike the national government, FACE Africa had developed trust with communities in Rivercess. They had also developed local socio-political leadership structures to manage the water and sanitation projects, which they were able to leverage to put together advocacy teams and Ebola Committees, training community members to join this response. As a result, Rivercess was spared the devastation that EVD wrecked across many communities in Liberia.

Reflecting on FACE Africa's growth, for Saran, the greatest challenge that she initially faced was raising funds for the organisation. In 2009, the organisation received a \$10,000 grant from the Davis Project for Peace, a Vermont-based charity, to implement its first clean water project in Barnesville, Rivercess. Later, they won a grant from Concern Worldwide, an organisation based in Ireland, and another \$20,000 grant from the Chase Community Giving program. FACE Africa has focused on social media and online newsletters to raise awareness about its work and generate a buzz. Currently 85% of all the funds they raise comes from online giving. FACE Africa recently participated in a grant challenge online and were able to leverage their social media followers to raise \$124,000 in six weeks.

All Saran's persistence has paid off. At the end of 2018, FACE Africa was close to reaching an important milestone. While it took double the time (nine years) and double the capital (\$3 million), FACE

Africa was finally on track to achieve its original goal of 100% water coverage in Rivercess county, in the process impacting over 115,000 people and becoming the first NGO in Liberia to achieve this feat. Saran wants her organisation to change the way NGOs do business in Liberia. She explained to me, 'As we are looking to prove this model in Rivercess, we hope to influence policies, and show that if we really take this water situation seriously and commit to it with the right partnerships, and the right level of commitment, we can solve this problem in all of Liberia. So that's the bigger goal that we are trying to accomplish, not just deliver access to water, which is our number one goal, but to also show that this can be achieved by being strategic about where we put resources. The government needs to get involved at this level, because we can't have over a hundred organisations that claim to be implementing water projects, and that have the resources and the funding to do it, but you don't see the impact.'

Saran doesn't want to work on FACE Africa forever. When I asked her where she hoped she'd be if I return to interview her in 20 years, she replied, 'Well, I would hope by then Face Africa doesn't exist, I would hope that we are still not around and digging wells, because that would be a major problem, that would mean we haven't done anything!' I am inspired by Saran's optimism, and that of her fellow Liberians, and the courage they all exhibit in deciding to pick up the pieces after the civil war and rebuild their country.

As I reached the airport to leave Monrovia, I was stuck by contradictory feelings of hope and trepidation. I was buoyed by Saran's work, by the signs of increasing development that were springing up all over Monrovia, but I couldn't shake the memory of what I had seen in Westpoint. Westpoint served as a haunting reminder to me that economic development and GDP growth is meaningless if it marginalises those at the bottom.